The Road Less Travelled

HERE'S A SELECTION OF SOME INTERESTING AND OFFBEAT DESTINATIONS TO VISIT IN TAMIL NADU THIS SUMMER

Summer brings with it the perennial question: Where to go for the holidays? Opting for Tamil Nadu as your summer destination is the perfect time to escape the heat of the plains and head to the sylvan hill tracts of the State.

While you may have been to some of the bigger and most popular destinations like Ooty, Coonoor and Kodaikanal, they can get rather busy at this time of year. Why not head to one of the lesser-visited but equally rewarding destinations of Tamil Nadu instead? They will sweep you off your feet with their relaxed, laidback vibe, scenic vistas, fresh mountain air and boutique stay options.


POOMBARAI

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Lying a mere 20 kilometres from Kodaikanal, Poombarai village is a true lesser-known gem of Tamil Nadu. Set among terraced garlic farms and scenic lakes, it offers stunning vistas from the Poombarai and Palambatur viewpoints. Scenic spots you can explore nearby include Polur Falls, Poondi Dam and Kookal Lake & Falls. The Kuzhanthai Velappar Temple is an ancient temple dedicated to Lord Murugan in Poombarai. A scenic trail starting at Poombarai brings you to Mannavannur Lake, a serene picnic spot perfect for families and holidaymakers. The shores of the lake are home to a wide variety of birds, making it the perfect spot for birdwatching.


MANJOLAI

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Located within the Kalakad Mundanthurai Tiger Reserve in Tirunelveli District, the hill station of Manjolai lies at an altitude of 1,160 metres. The scenic location set in the lap of dense forests offers several experiences in the form of tea estates, the Manimuthar Dam, and the Manimuthar Falls. It also boasts attractions like a mini golf course in Kakkachi, the Singampatty Zamin Palace, Vanapetchi Amman Temple, and Upper Kodayar Dam. Since access to Manjolai is through the reserve, prior permission from the Forest Department is required to visit.

KOLLI HILLS

Kolli Hills is a hill station in Namakkal District set among coffee plantations, fruit orchards, and silver-oak estates at an altitude of 1,200 metres. The hill station is noted for having the largest expanse of evergreen or shola forest cover in the southern part of the Eastern Ghats. The road to the top of Kolli Hills takes in 70 hairpin bends over 50 kilometres, making for a thrilling journey. Must-visit attractions include Agaya Gangai Falls, Vasalurpatty Lake, Siddhar Caves, and the Selur viewpoint.

YELAGIRI

Located in the newly formed Tirupathur District just off the Vaniyambadi-Tirupathur Road, Yelagiri is a hill station reached by a winding ghat road and 14 hairpin bends. There is much to discover and do here, from village walks to lakeside strolls. The Jalagamparai Waterfalls, Punganoor Lake, and Telescope Observatory are popular attractions. Paragliding is an exciting activity on offer here.


YELAGIRI

JAWADHU HILLS

The Jawadhu Hills in Tiruvannamalai District are an extension of the Eastern Ghats and separate the district from Vellore. Attractions include the Beemanmadavu Falls; Komutteri Lake, where you can indulge in some leisurely boating; Kavalur Solar Observatory, the largest in Asia; and Melpattu village, which is set at the highest point of the Jawadhu hills. The village has a Herbal Farm as well as ancient cave dwellings that are a big draw.

MASINAGUDI

A part of the Mudumalai National Park, the hill station of Masinagudi in the Nilgiris District is an experience not to be missed by wildlife enthusiasts. You can go on a safari through the forests of Mudumalai, where, if you're lucky, you might spot a tiger or a leopard. There are elephants, langurs, sloth bears, sambar deer, gaur and wild boar as well. Birdwatchers are in for a treat too. Or you can go boating on the nearby Moyar River. Other scenic spots are the Pykara falls, the Maravakandy Dam and the Theppakadu Elephant Camp.

With its host of offbeat travel options, Tamil Nadu has all the makings of a perfect summer getaway. So wait no more, and plan your summer sojourn to Tamil Nadu right away.


JAWADHU HILLS